written in Prakrit, a dominant political language in north India, as well as in Greek and Aramaic in north-west India. Inscriptions have been found as far afield as Kandahar in today's Afghanistan, Lumbini in today's Nepal, and in Gujarat, Odisha, and Karnataka. It is from these locations that an outline of the extent of Mauryan influence has emerged. [9] While they touched on issues of administration and justice, Ashoka's edicts were primarily focused on *dhamma*, Prakrit for *dharma*.

Contrary to popular lore, Ashoka was not simply a pacifist. While his rock edicts do recount his remorse at seeing widespread death and destruction during his victory over the Kalingas (in present-day Odisha), he did not reject the use of force against tribal chiefs or in future conflicts. Instead, Ashoka argued that his descendants must be merciful and moderate in their use of force. [10] Rather than a demonstration of hegemony or pacifism, Ashoka's edicts can perhaps best be thought of as an attempt to establish a rules-based international order in his extended region, perhaps among the first such attempts in history. Ashoka's edicts demonstrate a considerable degree of contact with the world at large, with references to contemporary rulers in Syria, Egypt, Macedonia, Cyrenaica (modern-day Libya) and Greece. [11]

In religious tradition and popular lore, Ashoka has developed a powerful reputation as a Buddhist evangelist and patron as far afield as today's Sri Lanka, Myanmar, and Thailand, where he is credited with sending Buddhist missions. (Mauryan and Shungan artefacts, such as ringstones, have been found as far as peninsular Thailand.) By the second century BCE, Buddhism had found patrons among the rulers Dutthagamini in Sri Lanka and Menander in Bactria. Ashoka's legacy lives on in the symbolism of the Republic of India, including the chakra on the national flag and the Sarnath Lion Capital as the state emblem.

It was in the Mauryan period (third and second centuries BCE) or shortly thereafter that a significant work called the *Arthashastra* was composed. The *Arthashastra* is a practical guide to statecraft in fifteen books of prose. It prescribes ideals for ruling a hypothetical state, which lends it a timeless quality, and offers lessons in realpolitik and maximizing power in ruthless